Cat Got Your Tongue?

By Sonya Sones

NOTE: written in poetry form but included in a prose anthology. Check the regulations for your tournament for the appropriate category in which to enter this selection.

It Feels Just Like I Dreamed It Would (Pg 120-168)

My skin misting all over,
my T-shirt clinging to me,
my breath coming in short, soft gasps,

my heart hip-hopping in my chest,
my hands trembling
and reaching out,

my fingertips buzzing as I take hold of it,
gripping it for the very first time,
slipping around it as if it were a trophy—
my very own driver's license!

INTRODUCTION

The day we turn 16 is a magical day, full of good wishes and birthday cake. For Bria this is also the day for newfound love and a cat that might steal her heart before she has the chance to give it away.

Cat Got Your Tongue by Sonya Sones

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Everybody Sing!

Happy Birthday to me,
Happy Birthday to me,
Happy Birthday, dear Bria,

Happy Birthday
to deliriously happy, totally independent,
sixteen-year-old, licensed-driver
me!

Actually, My Real Name Isn't Bria

It's Umbria.
And just in case you're wondering why
I have such a bizarre yet fabulously exotic name
it's because my parents named me
after a region in Italy.

Which, supposedly,
is the very region in which I was conceived.
So, as you might well imagine,
every day I thank my lucky stars
that I wasn't conceived
in Oxnard.

My Parents Told Me That It Happened in a Car

Not that I had even the eensy beensiest desire

to know that.

Mom says maybe that's why learning how to drive
came so easily to me.

So That Means

That even if my big brother, Paris
(can you guess where he was conceived?),
wasn't twenty-one years old,

it'd still be okay for me to be the one driving us up
to Aunt Ginger's place for my birthday luau

(her idea, not mine),

Levitating to My Luau in Paris's Mustang

Shooting through the night
like an arrow on the wind,
we're zooming past the orchards
with the top down.

Breezing down the road,
listening to rap,
my fingers have to tap,
have to dance to the music of the ride.

The car and I are one,

I could drive like this for hours,
I could drive us anywhere,

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drive us right up past the moon
to the stars.

Both of Us See It

This bullet of fur,

this tiger-striped shadow,
this smudge, this blur

that darts from the dark

We see it streak out.
But it's just

too sudden,
too fast,

too—!

I Slam on the Brakes

Slam them so hard
that wheels scream,
rubber burns.

"Oh, no!" I gasp.
"Did I hit it? I didn't hit it.
Did I?"

Paris doesn't answer.
He doesn't need to.

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I already know.

I know.
But I don't want
to know.

And I sure don't want to turn around
and see it lying in the middle of the road.
But I swivel in my seat and there it is—

a mangled mound of tiger-striped fur,
one delicate paw extended out of the heap,
as though caught in mid-swipe,

a small white moth
fluttering above it
in the blood red glow of the tail lights

as if trying to coax the little cat to life,
trying to lure it back
to the chase—

I rest my forehead
n the steering wheel
and cry.

I Guess Paris Must Feel Pretty Sorry for Me

Because he doesn't even call me Dumbria.
He just reaches over and switches off the ignition,
silencing the CD and filling the night
with the sudden echoing choir of crickets.

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He lets me cry it out for a few minutes.
Then he hands me a Kleenex,
tousles my hair, and says, "Geez, Bria.

I know you aren't particularly fond of kitties,
but don't you think you've gone
just a tad too far this time?"

Now I'm laughing instead of crying.
And thinking to myself
how much I love my brother.

But then that gets me thinking
about the people
who probably loved that cat.

And I break down all over again.

Paris Sighs

Then he puts his arm around me and says,
That there wasn't anything I could do.

"Believe me," he says, totally deadpan.
"Even if a good driver had been driving the car,
the same thing would have happened."

It takes me a second to realize
that I've just been insulted.
Then I start laughing again.

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He says, “Well, we better get going
or we’ll be late to your birthday luau.”

So I blow my nose one last time,
switch on the ignition,
shift into drive,

And flee from the scene of the crime.

Two Minutes Later

We pull up in front of Aunt Ginger’s house.
Paris commends me on my courage,
my fortitude,
and my parallel parking.

We head toward the front door,
but before we can even knock,
it sweeps open and Aunt Ginger yanks us inside,
hurling herself into our arms.

It’s like being hugged by an unusually friendly octopus
who just happens to be wearing a hula skirt and
one of those bras made out of coconuts.
(Ouch! Ouch!)

“Aloha, my darlings!” she cries,
flinging a lei over each of our heads.
“I want you to meet Leon,
my fifth and final husband.”

Leon stops strumming his ukulele

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and steps forward to pump both our hands.
He’s a Buddha-esque little man dressed only in a pareo,
with a belly as round as his gleaming bald head.

“Which one is the birthday girl?” he says with a grin.
This is apparently Leon’s subtle way
of letting us know that he’s noticed
the length of my brother’s hair.

“I am,” Paris says,
with a seductive bat of his eyelashes.
This totally cracks Leon up.
“You’re going to get along great with my son!” he says.
His son? No one said anything about a son.

Flynn Walks Through the Door

Suddenly
I’m staring deep into a pair
of swimming-pool-blue eyes,

these huge, dreamy,
heavy-lidded miracles
fringed with a forest of feathery black lashes.

I’m just
standing here
dumbstruck,
and my heart starts dancing the hula.

I’ve Read About This Sort of Thing Happening

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This hokey love-at-first-sight thing,
this sparks-flying-fireworks-exploding-
ohmigod-I-think-I'm-about-to-melt-into-a-puddle-
right-here-and-now-
all-over-the-floor thing.

But I never thought
it would ever happen
to me.

Or That When It Did

It would be with a boy
named Flynn.

I Let My Eyes Drift Down to Flynn's Lips

"Hau'oli la hanau momona 'umi kumaono," he says.
"Huh?" I say.
"It's Hawaiian for 'Happy Birthday, sweet sixteen.'
I've been practicing."

"Wow . . ." I say, temporarily stunned into monosyllables
by the husky sound of his sexy voice.
But a second later I manage to pull myself together
and purr, "I love it when you talk Hawaiian to me."

Then Paris says, "Hey, Flynn.
Can you teach me the Hawaiian words for
'How about them Lakers?'"
And Flynn cracks up, as Leon herds us into the kitchen.

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Aunt Ginger Tells Us She's Been Secretly Yearning

To throw me a luau for my sixteenth birthday,

Then she slips on an apron and asks my brother
to help her chop the onions and tomatoes
for the lomi lomi salmon.

Leon opens the oven to check on the kalua pig.
He asks Flynn to peel the sweet potatoes.
I offer to set the table, and head out onto the patio.

Alone at last,
under a full moon,
with my fantasies of Flynn . . .

I'll be setting out the plates
when he'll come up behind me and whisper in my ear,
so near that I'll feel the tingle of his breath on my skin.

"Do you need any help, Bria?"
But I won't answer.
I'll just lean back, pressing my body tightly to his.

He'll wrap his arms around me,
holding me so close
that I'll feel his heartbeat's wild drumming.

Then he'll start kissing my neck,
my shoulders,
my—

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"Do you need any help, Bria?"
I whirl around—
Ohmigod!

It's Flynn.

I Can Feel My Cheeks Flushing Hibiscus Pink

"Sure," I say,

"How about if you put out the napkins," I say,
trying my best to sound nonchalant,
"and I put out the plates?"
"Okay," he says.

I begin circling the table,
placing a dish in front of each chair.

Wherever I go,
Flynn goes, too,
gliding along next to me
as though we're doing the tango.

He begins passing me
the little paper umbrellas for the glasses.
That's when it happens—
his fingertips brush my wrist!

Suddenly, this quivery sort of shiver
flutters all through me
and Flynn takes a step closer,
his fingers finding mine, lacing us together.

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"Hey, kids," Paris calls.
He's standing in the kitchen doorway smirking,
with his arms crossed over his chest,
one eyebrow raised.

"Can you give us a hand grating these coconuts?"

I Muddle Through the Next Half Hour

Avoiding eye contact,
avoiding any contact
with Flynn the Magnificent.

Because it's entirely too weird to be falling for him
While his father is watching,
not to mention my aunt and my nosy big brother,

who for some strange reason
has decided that his baby sister is off-limits
to every boy on the entire planet.

When We Finally Head Out onto the Patio to Eat

Flynn practically breaks into a trot
to grab the seat next to mine.
This totally goose-bumps me.

We Share a Secret Smile That Lasts a Nanosecond

Then,
Flynn slithers his hand into mine under the table,

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and a dizzying current of energy surges between us.

"So, Flynn," Paris asks,
"were you in Maui with your father when he met Ginger?"
But Flynn doesn't answer.
He doesn't even appear to have heard the question.

That son of yours," Aunt Ginger says fondly,
resting her head on Leon's shoulder,
and smiling across the table at Flynn.
"He's such a daydreamer."

"What's the matter, boy?" Leon asks gently.
"Cat got your tongue?"
"Hey, speaking of cats," Aunt Ginger says,
"has anyone seen Bitsy?"

Did she just say "speaking of cats"?!
"Who . . ." I ask warily, ". . . is Bitsy?"
Aunt Ginger heaves a dreamy sigh and says,
"Only the most wonderful kitty on the face of this earth."

"She really is terrific," Leon says.
"I wonder where that little rapscallion could be.
It's not like her to be late for supper.
She's always home by eight . . ."

I check my watch—
It's 8:25!

My Heart Freezes in Mid-beat

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Under the table, Paris grabs my other hand.
We sneak a quick peek at each other.
He's obviously thinking what I'm thinking.
I squeeze his hand in panic.
Paris knocks back the rest of his Mai Tai in a single gulp.

"I hope that dear little cat hasn't gotten herself
into any trouble . . ." Aunt Ginger says.
And a line creases her forehead.
"Don't you worry, doll," Leon says.
"I'm sure our Bitsy's just fine."

"She better be," Flynn says,
finally emerging from his love trance.
"I've gotten way attached to the Bitster.
I can't wait for her to get home
so you can see her, Bria."

"Me neither," I barely manage to croak.
As Aunt Ginger's eyes start misting over.
"You know," she says, "if it weren't for Bitsy,
I never would have even met Leon."

Then she tells us this long story about
how she was taking a walk on Hamoa Beach in Maui,
and she was feeling so sorry for herself,

because there she was,
all alone in this tropical paradise,
letting this fabulously deserted beach go to waste,

when she heard this tiny mew coming from behind her.

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So she turned around and there was this scruffy kitten,
following right along after her.

"She could easily fit into a single one of my footprints,"
Aunt Ginger says.
"She was such an itsy-bitsy little thing."

"Hence . . . the name?" Paris asks,
with a visible lurch of his Adam's apple.
"Exactly," Aunt Ginger says,

not seeming to notice his oddly strangled tone of voice.

There's a Question Burning in My Throat

A question that has to do
with whether or not
a certain little wonder cat is tiger-striped.
But I'm way too scared to ask it.

"I figured she was lost," Aunt Ginger continues.
"So I picked her up and started knocking
on all the doors of the houses nearby
to try and find her owner."

"When Flynn and I answered our door," Leon says,
"there was this absolutely gorgeous woman
standing there,
holding this scrawny little feline in her arms."

Well, apparently,
one thing led to another,

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and the three of them spent the rest of the day together,
searching to no avail for the kitten's owner.

But before the moon rose that night,
Leon was in love with Aunt Ginger.
And they all were in love
with Bitsy.

"Which Was Totally Strange for Dad and Me," Flynn Says

"Because both of us had always been allergic to cats.
"But Dad and I decided that we'd rather spend
the rest of our lives on antihistamines
than have to give up the Bitsinator."

And Flynn
squeezes my left hand,
while Paris
squeezes my right one.

My Stomach's Doing the Jitterbug

then, Paris (says)
"What does the Bitserino look like, anyway?"

"Yeah," I say hopefully.
"What color is she?
Gray? Calico?"

"Nope," Flynn says,
pulling out his wallet, like a proud father,
to show me her picture.

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She's a cute little tiger-striped thing."

No!

Suddenly I'm choking on my lau lau.
Or is that my heart that's stuck in my throat?
Paris and Flynn start slapping me on my back.

"Dang hairballs," Paris says.
And everyone laughs.
Even Paris and me.

But anyone who took a close look at either one of us
would be able to see the ohmigod!!!
in our eyes.

Flynn Reaches for My Hand Again

Let's take a walk to see if we can find Bitsy, okay?"

Find Bitsy?!
Oh, man . . .

"Sure," I gulp, as Flynn takes my hand
and yanks me out the front door,

before Paris even sees where we went.

I Try

To steer Flynn

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in the opposite direction
from the scene of the crime.

But he says that Bitsy sometimes visits
the cat that lives at the apple farm
a few blocks down the road,
so we ought to check there first.

Now it's just the full moon dappling the lawns,
the echoing of the cricket choir,
and Flynn's long, warm fingers entwined with mine,
as we stroll together through the summer night
lit with stars and fireflies
and possibilities . . .

The only problem is
that every step we're taking
is leading us closer and closer still

to a certain heap of roadkill.

"Here, Bitsy, Bitsy, Bitsy . . ."

Flynn's calling softly to her,
in that husky voice of his—

that voice
that practically makes me swoon.

One block . . .
Two blocks . . .

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Now Flynn's telling me stories about his life.
Funny ones.

Stories that make me like him
even more than I already did.

The sound of his laugh, the feel of his hand,
those lips, those lashes . . .

"Here, Bitsy . . .
Here, Bitster, Bitster, Bitster . . ."

Three blocks . . .
Four blocks . . .

But I Can See It in the Distance Now

I can just make it out at the far end of the block—
the lump that's lying in the middle of the road!
The poor little kitty that I snuffed out . . .

Then, without warning,
Flynn slows to a stop
and pulls me around to face him.

But I keep my eyes trained on the ground.
Because if I look up into his,
I know what will happen.

And I can't let that happen.
Can I?
Can I?

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He Takes a Step Closer to Me

And brushes his lips against my forehead.
"Flynn," I whisper.
"Yeah?" he whispers back.

"There's something I have to tell you."

"What is it, Bria?" he asks.
"Is there someone else?"
"No," I say, closing my eyes tight.

"It's nothing like that . . .
It's . . . it's about your . . .
your . . ."

Suddenly,
something brushes against my ankle.
I leap back and then I see it—

it's something furry,
something soft,
something tiger-striped!

"Bitsy!"

Flynn cries, "Where have you been?"
scooping her up and burying his face in her fur.
"We've been looking all over for you."

"Bitsy . . . ?!" I gasp.

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"But . . . but I thought . . .
Ohmigod! Bitsy! It's you!"

"Mew,"
Bitsy says matter-of-factly,
gazing at me with her big yellow eyes.

I lean in to rub my cheek
against the softest fur in the universe
and then I find Flynn's lips

and kiss him!

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